



worry is Sayeed's proximity to the PMO. "The self-rule doctrine is the PMO's gift to the PDP and is actually the Centre's projection of how India wishes its peace process with Pakistan to shape up," says a senior NC functionary.

The Congress, disoriented by the loss of face over the Amarnath land issue, is conspicuously silent. The resignation of Ghulam Rasool Kar, who is now contesting as an Independent, has pitted former chief minister Ghulam Nabi Azad against president of Congress party's state unit Saifuddin Soz. The presence of several high-profile Independents has added to the possibility of the "unattached" becoming "king-makers" once again. There is speculation about senior politicians like former

**THE ABDULLAHS ARE FIGHTING
A BITTER BATTLE FOR SURVIVAL
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ASSEMBLY
Elections 08

PDP leader Ghulam Hassan Mir and M.Y. Tarigami of the CPI(M) besides G.M. Shah's Awami National Conference ganging up against both the PDP as well as the NC. Shah is Abdullah's brother-in-law and toppled his government in 1985 with the help of the Congress. Sources say these politicians are being widely consulted by the Centre for a "contingency plan" ostensibly to keep the PDP as well as the NC at bay. "Both parties are perceived as risky if they get an absolute majority in the legislature, as they may pass resolutions on self-rule or autonomy, which may embarrass New Delhi," says a political analyst.

Consensus is building up that the elections could permanently cast out at least one of the two families from the political arena. Till the last vote is counted, the Abdullahs and Muftis, however, remain the two main political forces to reckon with. ■

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